riyabhattacharya97@gmail.com

ORCID: 0000-0002-7244-8029
Scopus ID: 59243399200
WoS ResearcherID: PDX-0948-2025

Dr. Riya Bhattacharya

Academic Profile

Public policy scholar specialising in **urban governance**, decentralisation and governance in India. My doctoral research evaluates how the *74th Constitutional Amendment* has translated into service delivery and citizen participation across suburban municipalities of the Kolkata Metropolitan Area. The study combines household surveys, regression analysis and **geospatial methods**. At M.S. Ramaiah University of Applied Sciences, I designed and taught postgraduate courses in urban governance and quantitative methods. I also led MA students in **field-based GIS research** and equipped them with relevant statistical software, **R**. My publications appear in **Scopus-indexed journals**, including the *Journal of Urban Affairs* and the *Singapore Journal of Tropical Geography* and *Journal of Social and Economic Development*. Broader research interests span governance, citizen participation, urban migration and planning, policy evaluation, and spatial and mixed-methods analysis.

Teaching Experience

Adjunct Faculty August 2025 – Present
Department of Public Policy, *M.S. Ramaiah University of Applied Sciences*, Bengaluru
Courses designed and taught: Public Policy and Urban Governance (MA534A); Quantitative Methods and Data Analytics in Public Policy (MAC525A).

Field-based teaching: Led MA students in a field study of how drain flooding and traffic in Bengaluru affect the daily commute of university workers. Students conducted a survey of university staff and mapped flooding hotspots using GIS, applying classroom methods to a live urban service delivery problem.

Student feedback (MAC525A, PG Even Semester 2026): course evaluation average of **4.42/5 (88.4%)** across all parameters (5 of 7 enrolled students responding), with the highest score for course notes and handouts at **4.6/5 (92%)**. Comments included *"she's excellent"* and *"made coding simpler and easier."*

Teaching Portfolio

Urban Governance and Policy: decentralisation under the 74th Constitutional Amendment, municipal finance, ward committees and citizen participation, equity in service delivery, and peri-urban governance, drawn from my published research and doctoral fieldwork.

Public Policy Analysis using GIS: spatial data, geospatial mapping and hotspot analysis for urban policy problems in ArcGIS and QGIS, building on my training in geography and my field-based GIS teaching.

Research Methods for Public Policy: survey design, sampling, index construction, regression (OLS/probit) in Stata and R, qualitative coding in NVivo, and mixed-methods design.

Public Policy Evaluation: indicator-based assessment of public services and participatory institutions, and monitoring and evaluation frameworks for urban programmes.

Service Learning and Field Practicum: supervised field engagement with urban local bodies, ward committees and civic institutions, modelled on my fieldwork with RUAS students.

Additional: Development and Public Policy; Policy Communication, supported by my working papers and op-eds.

Research Experience

Research Associate June 2026 – Present
ICSSR Major Project: *Family Size, Ageing and Economic Development: A Comparative Analysis of India and Japan*
M.S. Ramaiah University of Applied Sciences, Bengaluru

Research Project September 2022 – September 2024
What Factors Influence the Performance of Women Leaders in Urban Local Bodies? A Study of Two Municipalities in West Bengal
Under the supervision of Prof. D. Rajasekhar, *Institute for Social and Economic Change*, Bengaluru

Education

Institute for Social and Economic Change Bengaluru
Ph.D., Development Studies (University of Mysore) 2021 – 2026

- Thesis: **Decentralised Governance, Participation and Service Delivery: A Study of Extended Metropolitan Kolkata**
- Advisor: Prof. D. Rajasekhar
- Methods: primary household surveys, probit/OLS regression, index construction, narrative analysis and geospatial analysis
- Degree awarded: August 2026, in accordance with UGC Regulations

Presidency University Kolkata
M.Sc., Geography 2018 – 2020

- Dissertation: **Suburban Dynamics: A Study of Dankuni Municipality**
- Percentage: 73.70

Gokhale Memorial Girls' College, University of Calcutta Kolkata
B.Sc., Geography 2015 – 2018

- Percentage: 67.00

Journal Articles

1. **Bhattacharya, Riya**, & Rajasekhar, D. (2025). Factors influencing citizen participation in ward committee meetings: Evidence from Suburban India. *Journal of Urban Affairs*, 48(8), 2668–2690. https://doi.org/10.1080/07352166.2025.2560954 **[SSCI, Scopus]**
2. **Bhattacharya, Riya**, & Guin, D. (2024). Suburban dynamics: A study of migration and governance in suburban Kolkata. *Singapore Journal of Tropical Geography*, 45(3), 426–446. https://doi.org/10.1111/sjtg.12560 **[SSCI, Scopus]**
3. **Bhattacharya, Riya** (2025). Citizen participation in suburbs: A study of Dankuni municipality, West Bengal. *Journal of Social and Economic Development*. https://doi.org/10.1007/s40847-025-00449-6 **[Scopus]**

Book Chapter

1. **Bhattacharya, Riya** (2024). What Factors Influence the Performance of Women Leaders in Urban Local Bodies? A Study of Two Municipalities in West Bengal. In *Women Leadership, Decentralised Governance and Development: Perspectives from Indian States* (pp. 115–135). Springer Nature, Singapore. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-97-3709-3_7

Peer-Reviewed Working Papers

1. **Bhattacharya, Riya** (2024). Urban Service Delivery in India: Status and Issues. *ISEC Working Paper* No. 594. ISBN 978-93-93879-57-8.
2. **Bhattacharya, Riya** (2022). Ward Committees as "Invited Space": Is It Successful? A Literature Review of Urban India. *ISEC Working Paper* No. 546. ISBN 978-93-93879-18-9.

Op-Eds

1. Heatwaves and Floods Expose India's Urban Policy Gaps. *Policy Circle*, (2026).
2. Digitising Urban Governance: The End of the Middleman Era? *Policy Circle*, (2025).

Work in Progress

1. Why do we need to move beyond coverage of service delivery? A study of metropolitan peripheries in India. *[Under Review]*
2. State capacity and schooling: The role of governance in educational attainment (with Dr. Kaibalyapati Mishra). *[Draft]*
3. Factors influencing basic service delivery in the periphery of metropolitan Kolkata, West Bengal. *[Draft]*
4. Paradox in the periphery: Financial condition and spatial indentation of municipalities of Kolkata. *[Draft]*

Conference Presentations

1. *Determinants of Basic Service Delivery in the Cities of Metropolitan Peripheries of Kolkata*. **International Conference on New Approaches to Governance and Resilience (NAGAR)**, School of Human Settlements, XIM University, Bhubaneswar February 2026
2. P*aradox in the Periphery: Financial Condition and Spatial Indentation of Municipalities of Suburban Kolkata*. **45th Annual Conference, Centre for Urban Economic Studies (CUES)**, University of Calcutta January 2026
3. *Challenges of Governing Public Water Supply: A Study of Suburban Kolkata*. **International Conference on Urban Water Management: Policies and Praxis**, Department of Political Science, University of Delhi February 2025
4. *Factors Influencing Citizen Participation in Two Municipalities of Suburban Kolkata*. **IPSA 75th Anniversary Conference, Challenges and New Directions in Multi-Level Governance**, Concordia University, Montreal April 2024
5. *Towards Effective Participation in Urban Local Governance: Understanding the Ways and Factors*. **International Conference on Urban Policy**, CHRIST University, Bengaluru April 2023
6. *Women Leaders in Urban Local Bodies: An Evaluation of Performance and Factors Influencing Leadership*. **National Seminar on Women Leadership in Decentralised Governance**, ISEC, Bengaluru November 2022
7. *Suburban Governance: A Study of Dankuni Municipality*. **4th International Graduate Seminar on the Quality of Living in Informal Settlements**, TISS, Hyderabad April 2021

Training

Programming ArcGIS with Python, Computer Aided Design Centre, Jadavpur University Dec 2020 – Feb 2021

Pandemic and Southern City II, Hyderabad Urban Lab March 2021

Skills

Software: `ArcGIS, QGIS, Stata, R (RStudio), NVivo`

Languages: English (Fluent), Hindi (Fluent), Bengali (Native)

Awards and Fellowships

- **Junior Research Fellowship (UGC-NET, Geography)**, University Grants Commission 2020
- **Research Conference Travel Grant**, ICSSR 2024
- **Dr. D. M. Nanjundappa Endowment Prize**, Gold Medal in Pre-PhD Coursework, ISEC 2022
- **Abhijit Bhattacharya Memorial Prize**, Top Scorer, B.Sc. Geography 2018

Peer Review

Singapore Journal of Tropical Geography

Development in Practice

Contemporary South Asia

GeoJournal

Letters in Spatial and Resource Sciences